The Cost of Convenience

Why Efficiency Is Not Enough

Economists have long assumed that productivity could be improved simply by removing friction. Yet the evidence, which has accumulated over two decades of workplace research, suggests something rather different. Organizations that strip away every unnecessary interaction frequently find that they have also stripped away the very exchanges from which innovation emerges. What matters most is not the speed of a process but the density of the connections that surround it.

There is no denying that remote work has reshaped how firms measure output. Although a digital order takes seconds to place, the warehouse worker who fulfils it may be evaluated by an algorithm that never pauses. Given that these systems are designed to optimise throughput rather than for human endurance, it is hardly surprising that turnover in such roles has risen sharply.

Hardly had the first automated scheduling tools been deployed when complaints began to mount. Not only did they ignore the preferences of staff, but they also made it impossible to plan a week in advance. Far from resolving the problem, the software deepened it.

Policymakers should invest in prevention rather than remediation. The more transparent a system of scheduling becomes, the more likely workers are to accept it. It goes without saying that technology itself is not the enemy; the difficulty lies in deciding who gets to set its objectives, and how that choice is reviewed over time. A system that nobody can inspect is a system that nobody can improve.

Some scholars argue that the second half of this century will be defined not by the invention of new machines but by the negotiation of new limits. Only when we treat those limits as a design question rather than an afterthought can we begin to build workplaces that are both efficient and humane. That is a conclusion the evidence has supported for years, even if practice has been slow to catch up with it.